

FORMAL GOWN

BROCADED SILK
MANTUA

The name “mantua” may have been derived from the Italian town of the same name where luxury silks were produced, or from the French word for coat – *manteau*. Originally an informal gown that was open at the front, the mantua was gradually draped back over the hips to reveal the petticoat beneath. Its shape changed again with the introduction of the hooped petticoat, an underskirt of canvas or linen with inserted rings made of whalebone or cane. The hoop took on several silhouettes, becoming wide and flat towards the middle of the century. Very broad gowns like this example from 1753 were reserved for formal occasions, when women wearing the mantua were obliged to slide sideways through doors.

Triangular stomacher panel decorated with silver lace and ribbon

Fabric woven of silk threads and strips of flattened silver metal

Pleated fabric over the top of bodice

Rigid bodice with a square neckline

Three layers of sleeve ruffles lined with silk and edged with silver lace

